MENT 3235: Midterm Team Project

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Item	What to do
Team	Same five-person team and selected startup plan; four section authors and one Team Leader.
Deliverables	One report PDF and one 15-minute team pitch video. Use the video upload or link field already provided in HuskyCT.
Who submits	Each member submits a contribution summary in SkillSimm; the Team Leader coordinates the graded report and video submissions in HuskyCT/Blackboard.
Deadline	October 13, at the existing cutoff shown in HuskyCT. This revision does not change the deadline.
Report length	No new page or word minimum. Answer every report criterion with evidence; use headings and readable tables.
Grading	Report: 100 points plus the listed report bonus (up to 5). Video: 100 points. Together this project is 20% of the course; report and video each contribute 10%.
Rubric	The report and pitch criteria in this document are the canonical rubrics; the general assignment guide links here.
Finished when	The report PDF opens, the video plays with accessible permissions, names are included, all required fields are submitted, and each member has saved their contribution record.

Submission fallback: If SkillSimm prevents access or submission, save the shared document as a PDF and submit the report/video through the existing HuskyCT assignments by their current deadlines. Include contribution notes and report the technical issue to the instructor. Do not wait for a team workspace to reopen to preserve your work.

Existing work: These clarifications do not add requirements or shorten deadlines for already-submitted work. Work completed under earlier published guidance will be reviewed against that guidance where versions differ.

Evaluate a Startup Plan and Develop an Improved Version

In this project, your team will evaluate an existing startup plan and use your findings to develop a stronger version. Think of this as an opportunity to practice making business decisions: ask thoughtful questions, test assumptions, and recommend improvements supported by evidence.

You will work with **one team and one plan across two submissions**. Each part includes a **100-point report (up to 5 report bonus points)** and a **100-point pitch video**.

Part	Points	Report responsibilities	Report submission
Part 1: Midterm	Report 100 (+5 bonus); video 100	Members complete Sections A–D; the Team Leader reviews and integrates the report.	The Team Leader downloads a PDF and uploads it to Blackboard.
Part 2: Final	Report 100 (+5 bonus); video 100	The Team Leader completes Section A; members complete Sections B–E.	SkillSimm captures a final PDF when the leader submits; submit the final report to Blackboard.

Your team will also create **one pitch video for each part**. See the Final Project Instructions for the next stage of the project.

1. Choose your startup plan

As a team, choose **one of the three plans below** before you begin drafting. Use the same plan throughout the project so your research and recommendations build on one another.

The descriptions below summarize the supplied plans. Treat their pricing, market, and operating claims as starting points to evaluate.

Roarmic

Read the supplied plan (PDF)

A browser-based microphone system for moderated events. Attendees scan a QR code and raise their hands digitally. A moderator gives one person the floor, and that person's voice plays through the computer connected to the room's speakers. The plan describes a working, deployed system with self-service pricing of $9 per month or $99 per year.

Marketing Email Agent

Read the supplied plan (PDF)

An AI tool that reads a company's commercial email, organizes information into a company-owned, searchable knowledge base, and drafts replies for human approval. The plan proposes pricing of $29–$99 per user per month, plus an enterprise offering, and seeks $2 million in seed funding.

Alien Chef Arena

Read the supplied plan (PDF)

A competitive browser game in which an AI Game Master scores player-created dishes against the needs of alien species and adds the outcomes to an ongoing story. The plan proposes a free-to-play model with a $6.99 monthly subscription option.

2. Work together as a team

Your five-person team will use **one shared Google Doc for both parts**. Open the document from your SkillSimm task; it will open in a new tab. Write Part 1 first, then add Part 2 below it when you begin the final project.

Use **team chat** to discuss ideas, coordinate revisions, and resolve differences. Check with your teammates before making substantial changes to their sections.

Team role	Midterm responsibility	Final responsibility
Member 1	A: Business Idea and Customer Problem	B: Market Deployment and Dominant Design
Member 2	B: Marketing Research and Value Chain	C: Technology Deployment and Competitor Analysis
Member 3	C: Operations and Business Model	D: Pricing Strategy
Member 4	D: Intellectual Property and Legal Structure	E: Financial Budgeting
Team Leader	Integrate, review, and submit the report	A: Incorporate Midterm Comments and Restate the Idea; review and submit the full report

The pitch video is a shared team responsibility. Work together to produce one video for each submission.

Team members

Complete your assigned section in the shared document, then submit your task in SkillSimm. Include a brief, accurate summary of your contribution. Google Doc edits may appear as "Anonymous," so your task summary serves as the record of your individual contribution.

Team Leader

Your task unlocks after all four members have submitted their tasks.

1. Read the full report and help the team bring its sections together into one clear, cohesive document.
2. Coordinate any final revisions before submitting.
3. **Download the completed midterm report as a PDF and upload it to Blackboard.** Upload the team pitch video or its working link in the existing video assignment. These are the versions used for grading.
4. Complete the leader submission in SkillSimm to unlock Part 2.

You will continue revising Part 1 after receiving feedback, so the separate midterm PDF preserves the version submitted for grading.

3. Midterm report — 100 points

Organize your report into the following four sections. In each section, connect your evaluation of the original plan to specific improvements for the venture.

A. Business Idea and Customer Problem — 25 points

1. Clearly describe the venture concept.
2. Identify the customer problem it aims to solve.
3. Explain the proposed solution.
4. Identify where the original plan misunderstands its customers, and explain how your improved plan addresses those gaps.

B. Marketing Research and Value Chain — 25 points

1. Identify the target customers.
2. Describe market needs using evidence from outside the plan.
3. Explain where the venture fits in the value chain.
4. Test the plan's market-size claims and explain whether the evidence supports them.

C. Operations and Business Model — 25 points

1. Describe how the venture would operate.
2. Explain how it creates value for customers and captures value for the business.
3. Identify major operational challenges.
4. Compare the plan's summary figures with its financial appendix, and explain any inconsistencies.

D. Intellectual Property and Legal Structure — 25 points

1. Identify potential intellectual property issues.
2. Describe the proposed legal structure and explain why it fits the venture.
3. Evaluate privacy, security, and data protection risks.
4. Propose a governance system: identify the decision-making body, its members, the evidence it reviews, and the activities or decisions it has authority to stop.

Bonus — up to 5 points

- **Up to 2 points:** Include a primary-source interview, with consent and appropriate attribution.
- **Up to 2 points:** Test claims against a statute, a filing, or a published price list.
- **Up to 1 point:** Provide especially clear writing or strong data-based evidence.

4. Midterm pitch video — 15 min 100 points

Create and submit a team pitch video that presents your improved venture and explains how your analysis strengthened the original plan. Organize your pitch into the following four parts, worth **25 points each**:

1. **Business Idea and Customer Problem — 25 points.** Introduce the venture, identify the specific customer problem, and explain your proposed solution. Show why customers would find the solution valuable and how your team improved the original idea. Points are assigned for a clear venture concept and customer problem (10 points), a convincing explanation of the solution's value (10 points), and a specific improvement to the original plan (5 points).
2. **Marketing Research and Value Chain — 25 points.** Identify your target customers and use research to demonstrate their needs and the market opportunity. Explain where the venture fits in the value chain, including the suppliers, partners, or distribution channels needed to reach customers. Points are assigned for a clearly defined target market (5 points), credible evidence of customer needs and market size (10 points), and a clear explanation of the venture's role in the value chain (10 points).
3. **Operations and Business Model — 25 points.** Explain how the venture will deliver its product or service, generate revenue, and cover its major costs. Identify a significant operational or financial weakness in the original plan and present your proposed solution, using figures consistent with your report. Points are assigned for a practical operating approach (10 points), a clear explanation of revenue and costs (10 points), and a feasible response to the identified weakness (5 points).
4. **Intellectual Property and Legal Structure — 25 points.** Explain your proposed legal structure and why it fits the venture. Identify relevant intellectual property, privacy, security, or data protection risks and describe how your team would address them. Explain who will oversee these risks and what decisions or activities they can stop. Points are assigned for a justified legal structure (5 points), relevant risks and practical safeguards (10 points), and a clear governance and accountability system (10 points).

Use clear audio and readable visuals throughout. Support your pitch with evidence from your report, and make sure every factual claim and figure shown on screen can be traced to that evidence.

Research and sources

The guidance below applies to both the midterm and final. Use evidence to test the plan's assumptions and support your proposed improvements.

Start with the supplied plan

The supplied plan for your chosen venture in this folder is your primary source for the original proposal. Cite it by section number so readers can locate the claims you discuss.

To develop an independent assessment, read the supporting details before the executive summary. Use this order:

1. **Appendix: Assumptions requiring validation** — What still needs to be tested?
2. **Appendix: Risk register** — What could prevent the venture from succeeding?
3. **Section 9: Financial plan** — Pay attention to footnotes, qualifications, and assumptions.
4. **Section 6: Operations** — What practical constraints must the venture address?
5. **Section 1: Executive summary** — How well do its claims align with the supporting details?

Reading in this order can help you identify gaps between the plan's overall claims and its underlying evidence. Explain those gaps constructively and recommend ways to address them.

Use outside evidence to test claims

- **Legal and regulatory sources:** Depending on the venture and its activities, investigate FERPA (34 CFR Part 99), COPPA (16 CFR Part 312), ADA Title II/III, Section 504, relevant accessibility standards such as WCAG, and applicable state recording and consent laws. For the email venture, consider GDPR and CCPA/CPRA as relevant. Explain which requirements apply and cite the original rule or authoritative source.
- **Competitors and comparable businesses:** Use SEC EDGAR to find filings. A comparable company's 10-K risk disclosures can help you identify risks to investigate. You may also draw on course cases, including TheRealReal, Affirm, Tesla, Cerebras, Snowflake, and Marvell.
- **Pricing and market claims:** Check competitors' public pricing pages, record the date, and save screenshots. Verify several competitor prices quoted in the plan and note any changes.

Learn from alumni interviews

UConn NetWerx can help you connect with alumni. Interviews provide firsthand perspectives that documents alone may not capture. Ask about challenges and trade-offs as well as successes. Obtain consent, take careful notes, and attribute insights appropriately in your report.

Additional resources

- UConn Entrepreneurship Business Plan Guide
- Reputable business reporting on market size and funding. Cite the outlet and date, distinguish reported estimates from audited figures, and use the evidence to check the plan's total addressable market (TAM) and serviceable available market (SAM) claims.

Feedback and revision record

Feedback identifies the report/video criterion, one specific strength, and one next revision. Keep a table with **comment → action taken → section/page**, or explain a reasoned decision not to make a suggested change. Use this record to prepare the final report's revision section.